02 | LADDER OF INFERENCE | DESK REFERENCE

Ladder of Inference Checklist

Use these questions before you make a decision or a request.

Step	What to ask yourself
1. Observe facts	What was actually said, done, or written down?
2. Select information	Which details did I notice, and which did I miss?
3. Add meaning	How am I reading those details?
4. Make assumptions	What am I assuming without checking?
5. Draw conclusions	What have I decided this means?
6. Form beliefs	What am I now treating as true?
7. Take action	What will I do?

Fact or assumption?

What happened	What I might assume	What I could ask
The reply said, "Please send your recommendation."	"They already know the answer and are wasting my time."	"Which decision should my recommendation cover, and what facts do you need?"

Before you decide or escalate

Name the decision. Check the current policy or procedure and who has the authority to decide. Ask the question that would fill in the missing fact. If new information changes the picture, change your conclusion.

A fact I can confirm: _____

An assumption to check: _____

My question and next step: _____

> **Urgent situations come first**
> If there is a safety concern or an immediate risk to services, use the required urgent process right away. Do not stop to fill out this worksheet.

Source: Decision & Escalation training, Supervisor edition, slides 8–9. Model: Trevor Maber, TED-Ed, "Rethinking thinking."

Learn more: Watch the TED-Ed lesson